were already becoming obvious. While China dominated Russian trade, Russia currently accounts for only 2% of China's total exports and represents 1.9% of China's imports. The growing disparity, exemplified in this imbalance fuels Russian concern that, more than a partner, it has now become China's *pridatok* (appendage). More importantly, China has become a presence to reckon with in Central Asia, building transport infrastructure in the region, sending workers, loans and aid, and now striking bilateral energy deals which, for the first time, have broken Russia's transit monopoly. China is mildly supportive of Russia's current role in Ukraine (in November 2014 Russian obtained a central bank liquidity swap line and a commitment of further financial help to contain the depreciation of the rouble).

But this is not so much solidarity as interest. For years Chinese negotiators have been able to get extremely favourable conditions for Russian energy exports, consistently imposing supplies under market price – the recent US$400 billion energy deal between the two parties attests to this loss of leverage, since the baseline gas prices finally agreed on (lower than those already paid in Europe) might not even cover the costs of laying down the pipeline which will deliver the commodity. While Russia digs in its heels to its west, it slowly gives way to China's energy security needs. Once more, Russian imperialism is contradictory and uneven, but ready to maintain its status whatever it takes.

Conclusion

My argument attempts to outline the real, often contradictory role of the Russian Federation as an 'emerging power' and member of the BRICS club, which embodies some of the most common aspects of contemporary capitalism at home (including an important level of elite integration and collaboration abroad). Simultaneously, Russia is the state most clearly opposed to the West on geopolitical lines. These lines of conflict over Ukraine are a central part of the argument here, as they not only confirm the imperialistic character of Russian foreign policy, but, in its latter stages, also showed the West's own understanding and awareness of the nature of Russia's imperialist contestation, whatever specific terminology they reserve for it. The clash of rival imperialist agendas now blown open in Ukraine offers a number of key lessons both in terms of Russia's 'emerging power' status, and the potential of the BRICS to really shift the global balance of power in coming years.

Firstly, and apart from any other distinctions which might set it apart from China, India, Brazil or South Africa, Russia ironically helps confirm that the BRICS do not pose an alternative to neoliberalism, but are rather, and like